

“REPRODUCTIVELY ISOLATED” ARE THE KEY WORDS

BIOLOGICAL SPECIES CONCEPT

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Ernst Mayr (1904–2005)

BEFORE

1686 Naturalist John Ray defines individual plant and animal species as those that derive from the same seed.

1859 Charles Darwin’s *On the Origin of Species* introduces the idea that species evolve through natural selection.

AFTER

1976 *The Selfish Gene* by Richard Dawkins popularizes gene-centered evolution: natural selection at a genetic level.

1995 *The Beak of the Finch* by Jonathan Weiner follows the work of biologists Peter and Rosemary Grant on the Galápagos Islands.

2007 Massimo Pigliucci and Gerd B. Müller use the term “eco-evo-devo” to suggest how ecology is among the factors affecting evolution.

By the early 20th century, it was accepted that multiple species could evolve from a common ancestor. However, it was not clear how this evolution process actually occurred. In fact, there was some debate about